

CHAPTER 22

MARIAM SPEAKS TO ME

'I am sorry'

At the end of our judicial custody we were taken to a court for extension of remand. This was done twice during my twenty-six-day stay in Viyyur prison. These trips to the court were an excursion of sorts. Besides getting to see the world outside the prison walls, we also got *vada, bajji* and tea, which were not available in the jail. Not that we were entitled to these snacks, it was thanks to sympathetic policemen who did not have the heart to have them without giving us.

It was during one such outing that Mariam Rasheeda spoke to me for the first time. My anger for the women and my other co-accused had abated, but still I was in no mood to look at the women whose background I knew little about.

'I am sorry.' Those were her first words.

Not interested in a conversation, I kept silent. She continued, in broken English, that she was innocent and knew that I too was.

'So why are you sorry?' I said.

'They beat me, threatened me. And I had to say bad things about you.'

She was referring to her confession statement before officials of the Kerala Police and the IB. They tried several threats, and finally she gave in when they said they would harm her daughter. The interrogators tutored her to say that I had passed on drawings of rockets to her for money, and this was video recorded.